OurMocks

2027 CYCLE

MOCK · PRACTICE · CRACK

CUET UG

History

Medieval Society Through Travellers' Accounts

Theme 5 · Through the Eyes of Travellers (c. 10th – 17th Century) · CUET UG 2027 Complete Mastery

INSIDE
Concept Notes

INSIDE
Solved Examples

INSIDE
Practice MCQs + Solutions

Aligned to the latest official syllabus · Concept-first explanations

www.ourmocks.com

Syllabus Alignment & Chapter Architecture

Sub-Topic Domain	Official NTA CUET UG Unit V Syllabus Scope	High-Frequency Cognitive Skills Tested
Al-Biruni & Kitab al-Hind	Khwarizm origin (973 CE); Mahmud of Ghazni invasion (1017); Sanskrit Indology; Arabic text (80 chapters); geometric structure; 3 epistemological barriers; critique of ritual pollution; Antyaja.	Evaluating cross-cultural hermeneutics; textual analysis of caste stratification; comparing Greek, Persian, and Sanskrit intellectual traditions.
Ibn Battuta & The Rihla	Tangier origins (1304 CE); legal training (**Shari'a**); trans-Eurasian journeys; Delhi under Muhammad bin Tughlaq; appointment as Qazi; diplomatic embassy to Yuan China (1342); Rihla written by Ibn Juzayy.	Contrasting empirical travel observation with textual Indology; tracing 14th-century commercial and diplomatic networks across Afro-Eurasia.
Flora & Urban Geography	Descriptions of unfamiliar flora: coconut (human head analogy, ship-rope fiber) and paan (areca nut and lime); urban prosperity; Delhi (28 gates, Budaun Darwaza); Daulatabad and Tarababad musical bazaars.	Analyzing medieval urban sociology; evaluating agrarian productivity and craft market commercialization.
The Postal System	State communication grid; Horse post (**Uluq**, every 4 miles) vs Foot post (**Dawa**, 3 stations per mile with brass bell-rod); 5-day news transmission (Sindh to Delhi); military surveillance and logistical supply.	Differentiating operational logistics of medieval intelligence grids; evaluating state administrative integration under Delhi Sultanate.
François Bernier's Binary Lens	French physician and philosopher in Mughal India (1656–1668); Prince Dara Shukoh and Emperor Aurangzeb; **Travels in the Mogul Empire** dedicated to King Louis XIV; binary European vs Mughal comparison.	Critiquing Eurocentric historiography; identifying theoretical premises of European superiority and colonial ideological foundations.
Crown Land & Socio-Economy	Crown ownership of land thesis; lack of private property; Montesquieu's "Oriental Despotism"; Karl Marx's "Asiatic Mode of Production"; Abul Fazl's **Ain-i Akbari** refutation; "Camp towns"; karkhanas; Sati; slavery.	Deconstructing property tenure myths; evaluating commercial guild independence (**mahajans**, **nagarsheth**); analyzing gender and subaltern realities.

CUET HIGH-SCORING INSIGHT & KEY COGNITIVE TRAPS

Theme 5 is a cornerstone of CUET UG History. Master these critical factual and historiographical details:

1. **Origins & Languages:**
   - **Al-Biruni:** Born in **Khwarizm** (Uzbekistan, 973 CE); wrote **Kitab al-Hind** in **Arabic** (80 chapters).

- **Ibn Battuta:** Born in **Tangier** (Morocco, 1304 CE); wrote the **Rihla** in **Arabic** (recorded by **Ibn Juzayy**).
- **François Bernier:** Born in **France** (physician/philosopher); wrote **Travels in the Mogul Empire** in **French** (dedicated to **Louis XIV**).

2. **The Postal System Terminology:**
   - **Uluq:** The horse post, stationed at intervals of every **4 miles** (**one kuroh/kos**).
   - **Dawa:** The foot post, operating with **3 stations per mile** (a dawa = $\frac{1}{3}$ mile). Runners carried a 2-cubit rod with **ringing brass bells**.
3. **Al-Biruni's Epistemological Barriers:** Three barriers: (1) Sanskrit language structure, (2) Religious/philosophical divergence, (3) Native insularity and ethnocentric isolation.
4. **Bernier's Ideological Legacy:** Bernier asserted that the Mughal Emperor was the sole owner of all agricultural land. This flawed thesis inspired Montesquieu's concept of **Oriental Despotism** and Karl Marx's **Asiatic Mode of Production**.
5. **Abul Fazl's Counter-Evidence:** The **Ain-i Akbari** proves land revenue was not rent on royal land, but **remuneration of sovereignty** (**kharaj/jizya**) paid by peasants for protection.

1. Al-Biruni and the Kitab al-Hind

Al-Biruni was born in 973 CE in **Khwarizm** (modern-day Uzbekistan), an ancient and cosmopolitan center of Islamic science and philosophy. He received an encyclopedic education, mastering Syriac, Arabic, Persian, and Hebrew. Although he did not know Greek, he was intimately familiar with Plato, Aristotle, and other classical Greek philosophers through early Arabic translations.

- **Arrival in the Subcontinent:** In 1017 CE, Sultan **Mahmud of Ghazni** invaded Khwarizm and captured its scholars and poets, bringing them back to his capital, Ghazni. Al-Biruni arrived as a captive hostage. However, he soon developed a profound academic fascination for India, serving the Ghaznavid court as an astronomer and scholar.
- **Learning Sanskrit in the Punjab:** Following the Ghaznavid annexation of the Punjab, Al-Biruni spent years residing in borderlands and northwestern centers of learning. He immersed himself in the company of Brahmana pandits, mastering Sanskrit grammar, poetry, and philosophy. He systematically read the Vedas, Puranas, Patanjali's **Yogasutra**, and the **Bhagavad Gita**.
- **Intellectual Cross-Pollination:** Al-Biruni translated Sanskrit mathematical and astronomical texts (such as Brahmagupta's **Brahmasphutasiddhanta** and Varahamihira's **Brihat Samhita**) into Arabic, while simultaneously translating Euclid's **Elements** and Ptolemy's **Almagest** into Sanskrit for Indian scholars. He admired the Indian decimal system and the revolutionary mathematical concept of zero (**shunya**).

The Architecture & Geometric Structure of the Kitab al-Hind

Al-Biruni's monumental masterwork, the **Kitab al-Hind**, was composed in lucid, elegant **Arabic**. It is an expansive treatise divided into **80 chapters** examining religion, philosophy, festivals, astronomy, alchemy, manners, weights and measures, iconography, laws, and metrology.

- **The Geometric Method:** Across each chapter, Al-Biruni adhered to an unwavering geometric methodology:
  1. He began each chapter with a sharp, clarifying question.
  2. He provided a detailed textual description based directly on Sanskrit canonical texts.

3. He concluded with a comparative analysis contrasting Indian institutions with those of ancient Greece, Sasanian Persia, and Islam.

The Three Epistemological Barriers to Cross-Cultural Understanding

Al-Biruni was uniquely self-conscious of the intellectual hurdles that prevented foreign observers from understanding India:

1. **The Linguistic Barrier:** Sanskrit was radically different from Arabic and Persian in grammatical syntax, phonetics, and root concepts. Subtle metaphysical nuances could not be translated directly into Arabic without substantial distortion.
2. **Religious & Philosophical Divergence:** The fundamental disparity in core theological assumptions, iconography, and sacrificial rituals made it difficult for an outsider to grasp social practices without deep immersion.
3. **Ethnocentrism & Social Insularity:** The local population, especially orthodox Brahmanas, displayed profound insularity and intellectual arrogance, believing their country was peerless, their religion superior, and their sciences beyond comparison. Al-Biruni observed that if you asked them about other cultures, they withheld knowledge and treated foreigners with suspicion.



Figure 1: Figure 1 — Cross-Cultural Travel Perspectives: Comparative analytical matrix contrasting the textual Indology of Al-Biruni, empirical ethnography of Ibn Battuta, and Eurocentric binary lens of François Bernier.

Al-Biruni's Critique of the Caste System & Ritual Pollution

Al-Biruni admired the philosophical depth of the **Bhagavad Gita** and Upanishads, but he subjected the Brahmanical concept of **ritual pollution** to a devastating rational critique:

- **The Law of Nature:** Al-Biruni argued that the concept of permanent social pollution was completely unnatural. In nature, everything that becomes impure strives to regain its pristine state of purity: the sun cleanses the air, and salt in the ocean prevents water from turning foul. If nature did not possess this self-cleansing capacity, survival on earth would be impossible.
- **Rejection of Inherent Impurity:** Therefore, the Brahmana doctrine that certain human beings are born permanently polluted was fundamentally flawed and contrary to universal natural law.
- **Description of Varnas & Antyaja:** Al-Biruni documented the four varnas (Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra), noting that while the top two shared close social privileges, all were

subservient to moral law. Below the Shudras were the **Antyaja**—eight groups of outcast craftspeople born outside the varna order (weavers, shoemakers, jugglers, basket-makers, and fishermen). Though socially segregated, they were economically indispensable to town life.

2. Ibn Battuta's Rihla: An Empirical Ethnographer in 14th-Century India

Ibn Battuta was born in **Tangier** (Morocco) in 1304 CE into an elite family of Islamic legal scholars (**qazis**). Educated in Islamic jurisprudence (**Shari'a**), Ibn Battuta was not a library scholar like Al-Biruni, but an inveterate traveler who believed that true understanding of the world came from firsthand physical observation and personal conversations.

- **The Young Pilgrim's Departure:** In 1325 CE, at age 21, Ibn Battuta set out alone from Tangier on the pilgrimage to Mecca: **"I set out alone, having neither fellow-traveller in whose companionship I might find cheer, nor caravan whose part I might join, but swayed by an overmastering impulse within me... I forsook my home as birds forsake their nests."**
- **The Trans-Continental Odyssey:** Over three decades, he traversed North Africa, Egypt, West Asia, Mecca, Yemen, the Swahili coast of East Africa, the Black Sea, and the Volga basin.
- **Arrival in Delhi (1333 CE):** Lured by the lavish reputation of Sultan **Muhammad bin Tughlaq**, Ibn Battuta crossed the Indus river in 1333 CE and proceeded to Delhi.
- **Appointment as Qazi:** Impressed by Ibn Battuta's Islamic legal erudition and foreign worldly experience, the Sultan appointed him the **Qazi** (judge) of Delhi with a lucrative salary. He served for nearly eight years until falling under brief royal suspicion for associating with a dissident Sufi saint, Sheikh Shihabuddin.
- **Ambassadorial Mission to China (1342 CE):** Restored to royal favor, the Sultan dispatched him in 1342 CE as the official Delhi ambassador to the Mongol Yuan Emperor of China. Traveling south through Central India, Malabar, and the Maldives (where he served as Qazi for eighteen months), he continued via Ceylon, Bengal, Assam, and Sumatra to the Chinese port of Quanzhou (Zayton).
- **Compilation of the Rihla:** Returning home to Fez (Morocco) in 1354 CE, the Sultan of Morocco commissioned the scholar **Ibn Juzayy** to record Ibn Battuta's spoken memoirs, published as the celebrated **Rihla** ("Travels").
- **Perils of Medieval Travel:** Ibn Battuta emphasized that travel was perilous and insecure. Caravans were repeatedly ambushed by highway robbers (**dacoits**). On multiple occasions, his traveling companions were killed, and he was once captured, stripped of his garments, and narrowly escaped execution, highlighting the raw physical hazards of medieval transit.

Describing the Unfamiliar: Coconut, Paan & Medieval Urban Wealth

Ibn Battuta delighted in recording novel everyday phenomena that differed from Mediterranean ecosystems:

- **The Coconut Palm:** He remarked that the tree resembled a date palm, but produced a fruit resembling a human head. It had two eyes and a mouth on its husk, while its inner cavity contained white flesh resembling brain matter, providing nourishing oil and sweet water. Its fibrous husk was twisted into durable cables used to stitch together ocean-going wooden planks.
- **The Paan (Betel Leaf):** He explained that the betel vine was cultivated on trellises solely for its leaves. Indians chewed the leaf with crushed **areca nut** (**supari**) and lime, which sweetened the breath, aided digestion, and imparted a crimson stain to the mouth.

The Metropolis of Delhi: Fortifications and Monumental Gates

Ibn Battuta left an extraordinarily vivid architectural description of the imperial capital of Delhi (Dehli):

- **Massive Ramparts:** Delhi was encircled by a colossal stone wall **11 cubits thick**. The ramparts housed guardrooms for night watchmen, storage magazines for grain and arms, siege engines, and ammunition.
- **The Twenty-Eight Gates:** The city was pierced by **28 monumental gateways** (**darwazas**), among which the **Budaun Darwaza** was the largest and most impressive. The **Mandvi Darwaza** housed the bustling central grain market.
- **The Congregational Mosque and Qutb Minar:** Ibn Battuta marveled at the great mosque (Quwwat al-Islam) and its soaring minaret, which he described as peerless in height, crafted of gleaming red sandstone with a winding internal staircase devoid of a central pillar.
- **Cemeteries and Public Pleasure:** Outside Delhi's ramparts lay an expansive garden cemetery where flowers like white jasmine and myrtle bloomed throughout the year, featuring domed pavilions where citizens gathered.
- **Daulatabad & Tarababad:** In Maharashtra, **Daulatabad** rivaled Delhi in commercial splendor, housing **Tarababad**, a specialized marketplace for male and female musicians and dancers, outfitted with ornate carpets, fountains, and curtained swings. Even Hindu and Muslim merchants frequented the street, where the provincial governor rode every Thursday to listen to public musical recitals.

3. The Imperial Postal Grid & State Communications

How did the Delhi Sultanate effectively govern an empire stretching from the Indus to the southern Deccan? Ibn Battuta was mesmerized by the speed and efficiency of the imperial postal communication network:



Figure 2: Figure 2 — The Delhi Sultanate Postal Grid: Operational relay systems flow contrasting the Horse Post (Uluq, 4-mile relay) against the Acoustic Bell Foot Post (Dawa, 1/3-mile relay).

The postal system functioned on two synchronized tracks:

1. **The Horse Post (Uluq):** Maintained by royal horses stationed at royal rest-houses (**dawa**) at intervals of every four miles (**one kuroh/kos**).

2. **The Foot Post (**Dawa**):** A pedestrian relay system operating with **three stations per mile** (a **dawa** equaled one-third of a mile). At every station, runners stood in readiness. Each runner carried a two-cubit-long rod fitted with ringing brass bells. As he sprinted with the mail pouch in one hand and the bell-rod in the other, the ringing bells alerted the runner at the next post, who grabbed the parcel and sprinted forward without losing a second.

Strategic & Logistical Speed

- **Transmission Velocity:** Dispatches from Sindh to Delhi, which normally required **fifty days** of ordinary journey, reached the Sultan in a mere **five days** through the postal relay! The foot post was consistently acknowledged to be faster than the horse post.
- **Logistics & Luxury:** The system was not merely used for intelligence and royal decrees; it transported delicate luxuries. Fresh fruits from Khurasan were carried across the mountains to Delhi, and fresh drinking water from the holy river Ganga was conveyed hundreds of miles southward to Daulatabad to supply the royal kitchen.

4. François Bernier & The Mughal Empire: The Binary Lens

François Bernier was a French physician, philosopher, and intellectual who lived in India for twelve continuous years from 1656 to 1668. Associated with the intellectual circle of the French philosopher Pierre Gassendi, Bernier operated within a strict Western scientific and philosophical framework.

- **At the Mughal Court:** Bernier served as personal physician to Prince **Dara Shukoh** (the eldest son of Emperor Shah Jahan) and later found patronage under Danishmand Khan, an influential noble at the court of Emperor **Aurangzeb**.
- **Travels in the Mogul Empire:** Bernier wrote extensive letters and memoirs published as **Travels in the Mogul Empire**, dedicated directly to King **Louis XIV** of France.
- **The Binary Comparative Framework:** Bernier analyzed Mughal India by constantly contrasting it with Western Europe. While European travel writers often praised the immense wealth of the Orient, Bernier viewed Mughal society through a bleak binary model: what was positive existed in France; what was decadent existed in India. He constructed an image of India as a dystopia of tyranny, decline, and economic degradation to convince European monarchs of the virtues of private property.

5. The Thesis of Crown Ownership of Land & Oriental Despotism

The core theoretical cornerstone of Bernier's entire analysis was his claim that **the Mughal Emperor was the sole owner of all agricultural land**:

- **Absence of Private Property in Land:** Bernier asserted that neither nobles nor peasants owned land. The king distributed temporary revenue rights (**jagirs**) to nobles, who could be transferred or stripped of their holdings at royal whim.
- **Disastrous Economic Consequences:** Bernier argued that because peasants and landlords were merely temporary tenants without secure proprietary rights, no one invested capital in long-term agricultural improvements (such as digging wells, building canals, or planting orchards).
- **A Two-Class Society:** Bernier asserted that India had no middle state or middle class: there were only the exceedingly rich rulers living in obscene opulence, and an impoverished, tyrannized mass of starving peasants: **"A king of beggars and barbarians."**

The Legacy of Bernier in European Political Thought

Bernier's erroneous crown-ownership thesis deeply influenced Western philosophy for two centuries:

- **Montesquieu & "Oriental Despotism":** The French Enlightenment philosopher Montesquieu used Bernier's accounts to develop his theory of **Oriental Despotism**, arguing that Asian rulers exercised absolute tyrannical power over subjects who possessed no private property.
- **Karl Marx & The "Asiatic Mode of Production":** Karl Marx drew on Bernier to formulate the concept of the **Asiatic Mode of Production**, arguing that surplus was extracted by a centralized despotic state through taxation because private property in land was non-existent.

Historical Refutation: The Evidence of the Ain-i Akbari

Modern historians have dismantled Bernier's thesis using contemporary Mughal Persian sources:

- **Ain-i Akbari:** Compiled by **Abul Fazl** under Akbar, the text makes it unequivocally clear that land revenue (**mal**) was not rent on royal land, but a **remuneration of sovereignty** (**tax**) paid by peasant proprietors in exchange for military protection and civil justice.
- **Peasant Ownership Rights:** Mughal documents show that hereditary peasants (**khud-kasht**) possessed inalienable rights to cultivate, inherit, mortgage, and sell their agricultural plots, provided they paid state land revenue.

6. Urban Sociology: "Camp Towns" vs Flourishing Commercial Centers

Bernier characterized Mughal cities with dismissive disdain, coining the term **"camp towns"**:

- **The "Camp Town" Hypothesis:** Bernier argued that Mughal cities (such as Agra, Delhi, and Lahore) were merely bloated parasitic military encampments that grew when the royal court and imperial army were present, and instantly shriveled into ghost towns when the emperor moved his military camp.
- **The Commercial Reality:** In reality, 17th-century Mughal India experienced rapid urbanization, supported by an advanced craft and commercial economy:
  - **Manufacturing Hubs:** Cities like Ahmedabad, Surat, Masulipatnam, and Murshidabad were dynamic centers of global textile manufacture, banking, and ocean trade.
  - **Merchant Guilds (**Mahajans & Nagarsheth**):** In western Indian cities like Ahmedabad, corporate merchant guilds (**mahajans**) exercised immense political autonomy, headed by a supreme merchant representative called the **Nagarsheth**.
  - **Imperial Karkhanas:** Monastic-sized state workshops (**karkhanas**) employed hundreds of specialized artisans to produce gold brocades, fine muslins, carpets, weapons, and enameled jewelry. Bernier himself marvelled at the precision of the artisans, who worked all day under royal supervisors, despite lamenting their lack of independent capital accumulation.
  - **Global Bullion Drain:** Indian manufactured textiles (cotton, silk, chintz) dominated global markets, drawing massive inflows of European and New World silver and gold into the Mughal economy.

7. A Panoramic Gallery of Other European Travellers

Beyond the famous triad of Al-Biruni, Ibn Battuta, and Bernier, a wide spectrum of foreign visitors left indelible impressions of medieval India:

- **Abdur Razzaq Samarqandi (1440s):** An ambassador from Herat who visited the court of the Vijayanagara ruler Deva Raya II. He was astonished by the city's seven concentric lines of fortifications, which enclosed agricultural fields, orchards, and water channels within the fortified city walls.
- **Duarte Barbosa (early 16th c.):** A Portuguese official who wrote detailed trade accounts of the Malabar coast, documenting trade in pepper, spices, and precious stones.
- **Jean-Baptiste Tavernier (17th c.):** A French gem merchant who visited India at least six times, captivated by India's diamond mines (such as Golconda) and comparing Indian commercial credit instruments (**hundis**) with European banking.
- **Niccolao Manucci (late 17th c.):** An Italian adventurer and self-trained physician who lived in India for over fifty years without ever returning to Europe, serving Dara Shukoh and compiling **Storia do Mogor**.
- **Seydi Ali Reis (1550s):** An Ottoman admiral who traveled overland through Gujarat, Delhi, and Lahore, leaving accounts of Indo-Persian interactions.

8. Commercial Instruments & Courtly Display in Travel Accounts

Foreign observers documented both the sophisticated financial instruments of Indian bazaars and the theatrical majesty of the Mughal court:

The Power of the Hundi (Bill of Exchange)

European merchants were stunned by the efficiency of indigenous banking networks operated by merchant communities (like the **Baniyas**, **Marwaris**, and **Chettiars**):

- **The Hundi Mechanism:** A credit instrument or bill of exchange whereby money deposited with a merchant in one city could be withdrawn in another distant city upon presenting the paper note, minus a small commission.
- **Trans-Continental Validity:** Indian **hundis** issued in Surat or Agra were routinely honored in distant trans-Asian trade hubs such as Bandar Abbas, Isfahan, Basra, and Cairo, proving that commercial trust transcended political boundaries.

Court Ceremonies & The Mobile Camp City

European envoys like **Sir Thomas Roe** and François Bernier described the elaborate theatrical rituals of the Mughal court:

- **Jharokha Darshan:** The emperor appeared at dawn at a small balcony overlooking the public palace grounds, showing himself to his subjects to confirm he was alive and well, before holding court.
- **Diwan-i Am and Diwan-i Khas:** Public petitions and military displays were staged in the **Diwan-i Am**, while confidential state business with high ministers and foreign ambassadors was conducted in the jewel-encrusted **Diwan-i Khas**.
- **The Two Sets of Imperial Tents:** When the emperor traveled for military campaigns or seasonal retreats to Kashmir, the court moved as a colossal "mobile city". The emperor possessed **two identical sets of royal tents**. While he resided in one camp, the duplicate set was dispatched ahead with camels and elephants to be fully pitched at the next stage of the route, ensuring the royal household stepped into a completely functioning palace upon arrival.

9. Women, Slavery & The Grim Spectacle of Sati

European and Islamic travel accounts provide stark windows into the lives of subalterns and women in medieval India:

The Institution of Slavery

- **Ubiquitous Slave Markets:** Both Ibn Battuta and European travellers noted that slaves were bought and sold openly in public markets, alongside horses and cattle.
- **Functional Differentiation:** Male slaves were used for agricultural labor, domestic service, guarding royal palaces, and palanquin carrying. Female slaves were prized for domestic chores, concubinage, singing, and acting as intelligence spies for the Sultan.
- **Slave Gifts:** Ibn Battuta routinely presented female slaves, horses, and textiles as diplomatic gifts to governors and Sultan Muhammad bin Tughlaq.

Bernier's Witness to Sati (Widow Burning)

François Bernier left some of the most harrowing eyewitness accounts of **Sati** in 17th-century India:

- **Coerced vs Voluntary Immolation:** While Brahmanical ideology claimed that Sati was a voluntary act of marital devotion, Bernier documented that many widows were violently coerced. In Lahore, he witnessed a young girl of barely twelve years old dragged weeping to the pyre, tied to the wooden stakes with ropes by Brahmanas and male relatives to prevent her escape, and burned alive as bystanders chanted.
- **Emotional Trauma:** Bernier expressed deep personal outrage at the inhumanity of the practice, noting that women who hesitated were physically beaten and shoved back into the blazing flames by relatives anxious to seize family property.

Comparative Historiographical Legacies of the Three Travellers

How should modern historians evaluate the distinct lenses through which these three celebrated travellers viewed medieval India?

- **Al-Biruni (The Philological Indologist):** Al-Biruni approached India as a detached, scholarly classicist. His reliance on authoritative Sanskrit texts gave him unrivaled access to high Brahmanical philosophy, mathematics, and astronomy. However, because his informants were almost exclusively elite Brahmanas, his writings sometimes reflected their theoretical biases, paying less attention to the routine daily lives of the subaltern working masses.
- **Ibn Battuta (The Empirical Anthropologist):** Operating within the vast, cosmopolitan cultural ecumene of the Islamic world (**Dar al-Islam**), Ibn Battuta was an insatiably curious, pragmatic observer of everyday human realities. He captured the dynamism of bustling bazaars, street performers, folk customs, architectural marvels, and culinary habits that library scholars overlooked.
- **François Bernier (The Comparative Political Philosopher):** Bernier represented the vanguard of early modern European political science. He evaluated Indian institutions through a prescriptive binary framework designed to influence French state policy under Louis XIV. By exaggerating the lack of private property and depicting the Mughal Empire as an impoverished, despotic wasteland, Bernier inadvertently laid the ideological foundations for subsequent European colonial intervention.

Female Agency & The Economic Role of Women

Travel accounts also reveal women's crucial economic contributions:

- **Artisanal & Agrarian Labor:** Women performed vital labor in agricultural transplantation, weeding, spinning cotton yarn, weaving, and selling merchandise in municipal bazaars.
- **Elite Commercial Enterprise:** Royal Mughal women, including **Nur Jahan**, **Jahanara**, and **Roshanara**, owned commercial shipping vessels, invested in trans-oceanic spice and textile trade

through Surat, and designed celebrated architectural monuments (such as **Chandni Chowk** in Delhi, designed by Princess Jahanara).

OurMocks

Chapter Synthesis & Cognitive Mindmap



Figure 3: Figure 3 — Medieval Society through Travellers' Accounts Summary Mindmap: Complete synthesis of Al-Biruni's Indology, Ibn Battuta's ethnography and postal systems, and Bernier's crown-ownership critique.

HIGH-YIELD MEMORY HOOKS & HISTORIOGRAPHICAL POINTERS

- **Al-Biruni (973 CE):** From **Khwarizm** (Uzbekistan); brought to Ghazni by **Mahmud of Ghazni** (1017); wrote **Kitab al-Hind** in **Arabic** (80 chapters); geometric method; 3 barriers (Sanskrit, religion, insularity); rejected **ritual pollution** via natural law.
- **Ibn Battuta (1304 CE):** From **Tangier** (Morocco); **Shari'a** trained; Delhi under **Muhammad bin Tughlaq** (1333); served as **Qazi** of Delhi (8 years); mission to **China** (1342); **Rihla** compiled in Arabic by **Ibn Juzayy**; described **coconut** (human head) & **paan**.
- **Postal Grid: Uluq** = horse post (every 4 miles); **Dawa** = foot post (3 stations/mile, bell-rod); transmission from Sindh to Delhi in **5 days** instead of 50.
- **Delhi & Daulatabad:** Delhi had **28 gates** (**Budaun Darwaza** largest); Daulatabad had **Tarababad** market for musicians and dancers.
- **François Bernier (1656–1668):** French physician/philosopher; court of **Dara Shukoh** & **Aurangzeb**; **Travels in the Mogul Empire** in French (to **Louis XIV**); binary European lens.
- **Crown Ownership Myth:** Bernier claimed emperor owned all land -> inspired Montesquieu (**Oriental Despotism**) & Karl Marx (**Asiatic Mode of Production**); refuted by **Ain-i Akbari** (tax = remuneration of sovereignty).
- **Urban & Social Reality: Camp towns** refuted by merchant guilds (**mahajans**, **nagarsheth**); **karkhanas**; open slave bazaars; graphic eyewitness account of **Sati** at Lahore.

MASTER STRATEGY CHEATSHEET — MEDIEVAL SOCIETY THROUGH TRAVELLERS' ACCOUNTS

- **Traveller Trio Comparison:**
  - **Al-Biruni:** Textual scholar; Sanskrit Indology; comparative philosophy; objective/ analytical tone.
  - **Ibn Battuta:** Empirical globetrotter; vivid travelogues; exotic wonders; socio-economic observation.
  - **François Bernier:** Political philosopher; Eurocentric comparative binary; private property advocacy.
- **Postal Track Speeds: Uluq** (equestrian, 4-mile relay) vs **Dawa** (pedestrian, 1/3-mile relay with acoustic bells); the foot post was often **faster** than the horse post!
- **Caste Outcastes (Antyaja):** Al-Biruni listed 8 groups of Antyaja (weavers, shoemakers, jugglers, fishermen) living outside towns but essential to economic production.
- **Mughal Urban Structure:** Beyond royal residences, cities were sustained by **mahajan** credit networks (**hundis**), imperial **karkhanas**, and international port commerce.
- **Sati & Slavery Realities:** Slavery was widespread across domestic and royal spaces; Sati was often violently coerced rather than voluntary devotion.

THE SEVEN FATAL CUET TRAPS

1. **Trap 1 (Language Confusion):** Believing Al-Biruni wrote in Persian. **Kitab al-Hind** was written in **Arabic**. Ibn Battuta's **Rihla** was also written in **Arabic**. Bernier wrote in **French**.
2. **Trap 2 (Uluq vs Dawa):** Mixing the distances. **Uluq** was the horse post (every 4 miles); **Dawa** was the foot post (3 stations per mile / $\frac{1}{3}$ mile).
3. **Trap 3 (Bernier's Royal Patron):** Assuming Bernier only served Aurangzeb. He was first physician to **Dara Shukoh**, and later patronized by Danishmand Khan under Aurangzeb.
4. **Trap 4 (Crown Land Accuracy):** Accepting Bernier's claim as historical fact. The Mughal emperor did **not** own all land; peasants held hereditary ownership as proven by the **Ain-i Akbari**.
5. **Trap 5 (Ibn Battuta's Author):** Thinking Ibn Battuta wrote the book himself. The **Rihla** was transcribed and edited by the Moroccan scholar **Ibn Juzayy**.
6. **Trap 6 (Al-Biruni on Pollution):** Assuming Al-Biruni endorsed caste purity. He explicitly **rejected** the concept of permanent social pollution as contrary to nature.
7. **Trap 7 (Tarababad Location):** Placing Tarababad in Delhi. **Tarababad** was the marketplace for musicians located in **Daulatabad** (Maharashtra).

Exam-Style Practice Questions & Detailed Solutions

Part 1: Al-Biruni's Indology & Epistemological Barriers (Q1 to Q5)

Q1. In which language did the eleventh-century scholar Al-Biruni compose his monumental encyclopedic treatise, the Kitab al-Hind?

(A) Persian (B) Sanskrit
(C) Turkish (D) Arabic

Sol. Q1. Language of Kitab al-Hind:

- Al-Biruni wrote his 80-chapter masterwork, the **Kitab al-Hind**, in simple and lucid **Arabic**.
- Although fluent in Persian, Syriac, Hebrew, and Sanskrit, he chose Arabic for scientific dissemination.

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**

Q2. From which ancient Central Asian region was Al-Biruni originally brought to Ghazni as a captive scholar following the military campaign of Sultan Mahmud in 1017 CE?

(A) Samarkand (B) Bukhara
(C) Khwarizm (D) Khorasan

Sol. Q2. Al-Biruni's Origin:

- Al-Biruni was born in 973 CE in **Khwarizm** (modern-day Uzbekistan).
- When Sultan Mahmud of Ghazni invaded Khwarizm in 1017 CE, he took Al-Biruni along with other scholars back to his capital, Ghazni.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Q3. Which of the following was NOT identified by Al-Biruni as one of the three primary epistemological barriers that hindered outsiders from understanding Indian society?

(A) The absolute lack of any written canonical literature in the Indian subcontinent (B) The complex grammatical and phonetic structure of the Sanskrit language
(C) The fundamental divergence in religious beliefs and theological principles (D) The deep insularity and ethnocentric isolationism of the orthodox Brahmanas

Sol. Q3. Al-Biruni's Three Barriers:

- Al-Biruni identified three main barriers: (1) Sanskrit language structure, (2) Religious/philosophical differences, and (3) Ethnocentrism/ insularity of Brahmanas.
- He recognized that India possessed a vast and sophisticated corpus of written texts (Vedas, Puranas, Gita).

Therefore, Option A was NOT a barrier identified by him. **Answer: (A)**

Q4. How did Al-Biruni philosophically refute the orthodox Brahmanical concept of hereditary ritual pollution?

(A) By appealing to the authority of Persian royal decrees (B) By citing classical Greek legal codes of Solon
(C) By arguing from the laws of nature, demonstrating that everything polluted strives to regain its pristine state (D) By claiming that all economic crafts should be performed by the state

Sol. Q4. Al-Biruni's Critique of Ritual Pollution:

- Al-Biruni rejected hereditary ritual pollution as contrary to universal natural law.
- He demonstrated that in nature, the sun purifies the air and sea salt prevents water from turning foul; without self-purification, survival would be impossible.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Q5. According to Al-Biruni's classification of Indian society, who were the 'Antyaja'?

(A) Eight occupational craft groups born outside the fourfold varna framework (B) Hereditary Kshatriya military commanders
(C) Royal ministers appointed by the Ghaznavid sultan (D) Brahmana scholars specializing in astronomical calculations

Sol. Q5. The Antyaja in Al-Biruni's Account:

- The **Antyaja** were eight occupational groups (weavers, shoemakers, jugglers, basket-makers, etc.) born outside the four varnas.
- Though socially segregated and considered low-born, they were essential to the urban economy.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Part 2: Ibn Battuta, Urban Networks & The Postal Grid (Q6 to Q10)

Q6. The celebrated fourteenth-century traveler Ibn Battuta, author of the Rihla, was a native of which North African city?

(A) Cairo (B) Tangier
(C) Tunis (D) Fez

Sol. Q6. Origin of Ibn Battuta:

- Ibn Battuta was born in 1304 CE in **Tangier**, Morocco, into an elite family respected for Islamic legal scholarship (**Shari'a**).

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Q7. Which Sultan of Delhi appointed Ibn Battuta as the Qazi (judge) of Delhi and subsequently dispatched him as an imperial ambassador to the Yuan Mongol court in China?

(A) Alauddin Khalji (B) Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq
(C) Muhammad bin Tughlaq (D) Firuz Shah Tughlaq

Sol. Q7. Patronage of Muhammad bin Tughlaq:

- Sultan **Muhammad bin Tughlaq** appointed Ibn Battuta as Qazi of Delhi around 1334 CE and later sent him as his official ambassador to the Mongol Yuan emperor in China in 1342 CE.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Q8. In Ibn Battuta's vivid ethnographic accounts of medieval Indian flora, what unique fruit did he compare to a human head, noting its eyes, mouth, and brain-like kernel?

(A) The Coconut (B) The Mango
(C) The Jackfruit (D) The Betel nut

Sol. Q8. Ibn Battuta on the Coconut:

- Ibn Battuta compared the **coconut** to a human head, pointing out that its husk possessed two eyes and a mouth, and its interior contained white kernel resembling human brain matter.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Q9. In the sophisticated postal and intelligence system of the Delhi Sultanate, how was the pedestrian foot-relay post known as the 'Dawa' structured?

(A) Single runners sprinted forty miles without rest along desert trails (B) Operating with three stations per mile, where runners carried rods with ringing brass bells
(C) Using trained homing pigeons stationed at royal fortress towers (D) Mounted cavalry galloping between fortified provincial capitals every twenty miles

Sol. Q9. The Dawa Foot Post:

- The **Dawa** operated with **three stations per mile** (a dawa was one-third of a mile).
- Runners carried dispatches in one hand and a two-cubit rod with ringing brass bells in the other, alerting the next runner in advance.

Therefore, Option B accurately describes the Dawa system. **Answer: (B)**

Q10. What was 'Tarababad', which Ibn Battuta described with fascination during his visit to the city of Daulatabad in Maharashtra?

(A) An imperial arms manufacturing factory producing siege engines (B) A segregated quarantine hospital for infectious diseases
(C) A specialized royal treasury containing Deccan gold booty (D) A vibrant marketplace dedicated exclusively to male and female singers, musicians, and dancers

Sol. Q10. Tarababad in Daulatabad:

- **Tarababad** was an extraordinary marketplace in Daulatabad dedicated to male and female singers and entertainers, outfitted with swings, carpets, and fountains.

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**

Part 3: François Bernier, Crown Land & Comparative Historiography (Q11 to Q15)

Q11. François Bernier, who spent twelve years in India (1656–1668), dedicated his famous publication 'Travels in the Mogul Empire' to which European monarch?

(A) King Louis XIV of France
(B) King Charles II of England
(C) Emperor Leopold I of the Holy Roman Empire
(D) King Philip IV of Spain

Sol. Q11. Dedication to King Louis XIV:

- François Bernier dedicated his memoirs, **Travels in the Mogul Empire**, to **King Louis XIV** of France, structuring his observations to advise the French crown on the supremacy of private property.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Q12. What was the central theoretical premise advanced by François Bernier regarding property ownership in Mughal India?

(A) Land was owned communally by democratic village panchayats
(B) The Mughal Emperor was the sole legal owner of all land, resulting in the absence of private property
(C) Brahmanas held inalienable proprietary ownership over all agrarian holdings
(D) European trading corporations possessed sovereign ownership over all coastal territories

Sol. Q12. Bernier's Crown Ownership Thesis:

- Bernier claimed that the Mughal Emperor was the sole owner of all land.
- He argued that the lack of private property prevented capital investment, ruining agriculture and impoverishing the populace.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Q13. Which French Enlightenment philosopher drew upon François Bernier's travel accounts to formulate the political theory of 'Oriental Despotism'?

(A) Voltaire
(B) Jean-Jacques Rousseau
(C) Montesquieu
(D) Denis Diderot

Sol. Q13. Montesquieu and Oriental Despotism:

- The French philosopher **Montesquieu** utilized Bernier's thesis to develop his model of **Oriental Despotism**, asserting that Asian rulers held absolute tyrannical power over property-less subjects.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Q14. Which seventeenth-century French gem merchant visited India at least six times and wrote extensively about diamond mines, comparing Indian commercial systems with Iran and the Ottoman empire?

(A) François Bernier
(B) Jean-Baptiste Tavernier
(C) Duarte Barbosa
(D) Niccolao Manucci

Sol. Q14. Tavernier's Commercial Observations:

- **Jean-Baptiste Tavernier**, a French jeweler and gem merchant, traveled to India six times, leaving valuable records of diamond commerce (e.g. Golconda) and sophisticated credit networks (**hundis**).

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Q15. In commercial urban centers of western India like Ahmedabad during the Mughal era, what was the title of the supreme head of the merchant guilds (mahajans)?

(A) Qazi
(B) Kotwal
(C) Subahdar
(D) Nagarsheth

Sol. Q15. The Nagarsheth:

- In western Indian mercantile cities, the corporate guild community (**mahajans**) was headed by a chief merchant representative known as the **Nagarsheth**.
- This proves that Indian cities were dynamic commercial centers with strong civic autonomy, not merely "camp towns".

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**